Uppsala Monitoring Centre

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What's New in WHODrug

March 2026

UMC's Drug Dictionary – WHODrug Global is a global and standardised terminology for medicines and vaccines, developed, maintained and distributed by Uppsala Monitoring Centre (UMC), an independent, not-for-profit foundation.

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What's New in WHODrug March 2026

Uppsala Monitoring Centre (UMC) continuously develops UMC's Drug Dictionary, WHODrug Global, to meet user needs and support regulatory compliance worldwide. This document summarises the most important recent developments, explaining briefly why they were made and how they affect WHODrug users. It also describes several updates to WHODrug content.

With the March 2026 release, ISO Identification of Medicinal Products (ISO IDMP) data is now easily available through links to WHODrug. The ISO IDMP standards provide a universal framework of structured, coded data for uniquely describing medicinal products, supporting the creation of global identifiers and ensuring consistent product information throughout their life cycle. Linking WHODrug's standardised terminology and detailed medicinal product information to IDMP identifiers created according to this framework gives users the best of both worlds: internationally aligned data structures that support emerging regulatory requirements, combined with coding-friendly, comprehensive medicinal product terminology and established classifications.

The scope of WHODrug continues to grow. The March 2026 release includes more than 688,000 unique product names and over 5 million medicinal products from 175 countries.

Descriptions of core WHODrug concepts, such as the Drug code and ATC classification, can be found in the WHODrug User guide, available in the WHODrug section of the UMC website.

2026 changes to WHODrug

The changes introduced ensure compatibility with new standards and regulations. They also improve usability without affecting existing key structures. These changes have been applied across all WHODrug tools and documentation where relevant.

Renamed concepts

Several key concepts have been renamed for clarity.

- Preferred records are now Substance records.
- Generic records with a drug code ending in a number higher than 001 are now Substance synonym records. These records share the same Drug Record Number and Sequence number 1 as their corresponding Substance record.
- Old form is now Archived record.
- Medicinal Product ID (MPID) is now Record ID (RID).

Removal of brackets on Non-unique substance synonym records

To harmonise how Substance records and Non-unique substance synonym records are displayed in WHODrug and to support auto-encoding, the ingredient information in brackets previously used for Non-unique substance synonym records in the B3 format has been removed.

New C3 format record level

A new C3 format record level has been added to match ISO IDMP granularity more closely. This record specifies the product name, active ingredient(s), country of sale, marketing authorisation holder (MAH), and strength.

New medicinal product identifier

The UMC Product ID is designed to define a medicinal product record in the C3 format. It is assigned, in addition to the C3 RID, to the most specific C3 record in WHODrug, which defines the trade name, active ingredient(s), country of sale, MAH, form and strength.

WHODrug files

End of data delivery in .txt format

WHODrug files, including add-on product files, are now provided only in .csv format because .txt files cannot manage large data sets and non-Latin characters well. File descriptions for the .csv format are included in each file package.

ISO IDMP data and mappings

ISO IDMP data and the mappings between IDMP identifiers and WHODrug C3 RIDs are included in the WHODrug file package.

New additional feature files

Two new additional feature files are now available:

- Archived record: lists all RIDs marked as Archived record. Previously, this was indicated in the Name specifier field as /old form/.
- Local drug name WHODrug Global: a sample file containing local drug names in their original characters. For countries where PhPIDs are generated, local trade names in selected languages will be included on request from the regulator.

Deprecated legacy C3 files

The C3 main file Pharmaceutical Product (PP) and the C3 subsidiary file Product Group (PRG) are now deprecated and no longer included in the WHODrug C3 format file package.

WHODrug Download API

The WHODrug Download API provides real-time WHODrug data to national regulatory authorities. Version 3.0 is now available and aligned with the 2026 WHODrug changes. Detailed guidance is available in the API documentation on the UMC API portal.

WHODrug Insight

WHODrug Insight offers instant access to all WHODrug data, supporting efficient coding and analysis in clinical trials and safety reporting. It remains the most widely used WHODrug application, with about 35,000 drug name searches daily. Several improvements have been introduced:

CDG upversioning

WHODrug Customised Drug Groupings (CDGs) are manually created groupings of medicinal products based on defined inclusion and exclusion criteria. WHODrug users can now automatically upversion their CDGs stored in WHODrug Insight.

Drug Search tab improvements

The product type filter and column names now match the 2026 updates. The /old form/ text has been removed from the Name specifier field, and the country-level flag has been updated to Archived record. The previous C3 detail pop-up has been removed. Users are now redirected to the Extended Drug Search tab for detailed C3 information.

Extended Drug Search (formerly WHODrug MPID Search)

To better reflect the purpose and functionality of the search tab, the WHODrug MPID Search has been renamed Extended Drug Search.

Less frequently used filters for Record ID, Drug code, Korean Substance ID and Korean Product ID are now grouped under Other. In the search results, the header Products has been renamed to WHODrug records. The text /old form/ no longer appears in the Name specifier; instead, an additional column can be added to show the Archived record status. Support for wildcard searches using the asterisk (*) has been added, and a "select all" option has been included in the dropdown list of suggested search terms. It is also possible to search specifically for Archived records in Extended Drug Search.

ISO IDMP data in Extended Drug Search

ISO IDMP data is now available in the Extended Drug Search tab. Users can view mapped global PhPIDs and related pharmaceutical product information when searching for WHODrug records. It is also possible to search directly for specific PhPIDs to find the corresponding WHODrug RIDs.

WHODrug Koda

WHODrug Koda is UMC's proprietary drug coding engine designed to improve coding efficiency and consistency. Built on advanced coding algorithms and artificial intelligence through machine learning, WHODrug Koda is available to WHODrug users both as an API service and as a web-based application.

To align with structural changes in WHODrug, the web interface and the export file format have been updated. The Koda API has also been released in version 4.0 to reflect these changes.

UMC website

The UMC website has been updated to make WHODrug information easier to access.

The WHODrug User Area has been removed. All training materials – guides, guidelines, documentation, webinars and event information – are available directly in the WHODrug section of the website. Many of these resources can be accessed without logging in, while some materials still require authentication.

WHODrug documentation

All WHODrug-related documents are now collected in one place on the UMC website: the WHODrug documentation section. This makes it easier for users to find the resources they need.

Certain key documents are updated and published with each new WHODrug release. These include essential guides and verification documents that help users stay informed about the latest updates.

With the March 2026 terminology release, most WHODrug documentation has been updated to reflect the changes implemented across WHODrug tools and downloadable files.

WHODrug online training

New self-paced courses

A redesigned WHODrug online course series is now available, consisting of six focused courses covering WHODrug basics, structure, coding practice, and how to aggregate and analyse data using WHODrug's hierarchy and classifications.

Courses are currently available in English, with Spanish and Portuguese planned for later in the year.

Updated Essentials webinars

The Essentials webinar series is pre-recorded and helps new users learn WHODrug fundamentals. Sessions are available in English, Spanish, Chinese, Japanese, Korean, and Portuguese.
Updated AI-generated presentations are now available on the UMC website. All sessions are reviewed and validated by WHODrug experts to ensure accuracy and quality.

Introduction to ISO IDMP

Launched in October 2025, this online training course provides a foundational overview of ISO IDMP, with a focus on global PhPIDs. It is open to all and is designed to help build essential knowledge for effective implementation.

Standardised Drug Groupings (SDGs)

WHODrug SDGs are groupings of medications with shared properties. They enable standardised and unbiased searches for related drugs.

UMC collaborates with a working group of experts to develop the SDGs. New SDGs, along with extensive updates and revisions to existing SDGs and subgroups, are delivered in the March release. The SDG content is updated twice yearly with each WHODrug release, together with an updated SDG User Guide.

New SDGs for March 2026

- **Drugs used in obesity**: includes drugs with obesity as an indication in approved product labels.
- **LiverTox list of hepatotoxic agents**: includes drugs listed in the copyright free LiverTox list from the US's National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases.
- Two new subgroups, **Monoclonal antibodies against interleukin 7** and **Monoclonal antibodies against interleukin 8**, were added to the subgroup Monoclonal antibodies against cytokines in the SDG Monoclonal antibodies.

Substance updates

To keep WHODrug current, the terminology is continually updated with new substances. This includes monitoring the International Non-proprietary Names (INNs) lists for new drugs. Since last year, herbal substance names have been aligned continuously with updates from the Medicinal Plant Names Services (Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew).

The structure for active ingredients and variations for biological substances has been revised to improve consistency. Substances with similar amino acid sequences but different origins (for example, blood coagulation factors) are now connected through new variations for human-derived and recombinant forms. In contrast, substances with different amino acid sequences (for example, interleukins) are no longer linked as variations but are separated into their own bases. This also applies to substances with a designated INN, which are separated into their own bases regardless of sequence similarity. Examples are provided in Table 1.

Table 1. Examples of updated groupings for biological substances.

Drug code	Substance name
003098 01 001	Factor I (fibrinogen)
003098 02 001	Factor I (fibrinogen), human-derived
003098 03 001	Factor I (fibrinogen), recombinant
009213 01 001	Interleukins
176094 01 001	Interleukin-2
176092 01 001	Celmoleukin

Umbrella records

Umbrella records represent defined groups of drugs and are used for coding imprecise verbatim when coding to specific drug names is not possible. Based on user requests, four Umbrella records have been added to WHODrug over the past year. The new Umbrella records in the March 2026 release of WHODrug are listed in Table 2.

Table 2. New Umbrella records in WHODrug March 2026.

Drug code	Umbrella name	ATC code
901612 01 001	Antisense oligonucleotides	C10AX, L01XX, M09AX, N07XX, S01AD, S01XA
901615 01 001	Cellular-mesenchymal-epithelial transition factor (c-MET) kinase inhibitors	L01EP
901613 01 001	Monoclonal antibodies	J06BC, J06BD, L01F, L04AG
901614 01 001	Neonatal fragment crystallizable receptor (FcRn) inhibitors	L04AL

ATC assignments

Annual ATC revision

ATC assignments in WHODrug are updated every year to ensure compliance with the ATC guidelines from the WHO Collaborating Centre for Drug Statistics Methodology. Changes to ATC codes or texts in these guidelines affect the ATC classification of trade names and substances in WHODrug. The major changes in WHODrug for the 2026 ATC revision are described below. For all ATC changes, see the ATC/DDD website.

New ATC codes

Three new 4th-level ATC codes were introduced in the March 2026 version of WHODrug:

- **J07BP** Chikungunya vaccines
- **L01EP** Cellular-mesenchymal-epithelial transition factor (c-MET) kinase inhibitors
- **L04AL** Neonatal fragment crystallizable receptor (FcRn) inhibitors

The new 4th-level ATC codes, which provide greater detail and specificity, have resulted in altered ATC assignments for affected substances. In addition, 96 new 5th-level ATC codes were added and assigned to relevant substances or substance combinations.

Additional guideline clarifications

The guidelines for "B05BB Solutions affecting the electrolyte balance" and "B05XA Electrolyte solutions" have been updated. The key clarifications are as follows:

- **B05XA** should be assigned for preparations that do not exhibit the properties of fluid-replacement solutions.
- **B05BB** should be assigned to fluid-replacement solutions.
- Diluted products can be classified under B05XA, even if described as "concentrates", provided they do not have the characteristics of fluid-replacement solutions.

Additional ATC assignments

During 2025, around 50 substances with linked medicinal products were updated with additional, UMC-assigned ATC codes to reflect new indications of use. For example, Caroverine (previously assigned only "A03AX Other drugs for functional gastrointestinal disorders") is now also assigned "S02D Other otologicals" to reflect the indication "Cochlear synaptic tinnitus".

Questions?

For any questions, please contact UMC at support@who-umc.org.

Uppsala Monitoring Centre (UMC) is an independent, self-funded, non-profit foundation established in 1978 dedicated to safer use of medicines and vaccines. Through an agreement between the Government of Sweden and the World Health Organization (WHO), UMC operates the WHO Programme for International Drug Monitoring, supporting over 180 member countries and regions in strengthening safety surveillance, and maintains VigiBase, the WHO global database of adverse event reports. In addition, UMC provides international standards and related digital solutions for secure exchange of pharmacovigilance data, including a global medicine and vaccine terminology for identification of medicinal products. With around 200 staff, UMC advances the science of pharmacovigilance and transforms its practice through technological innovation.

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